DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Four Species, Two Enemies: Sukkot, Hanukkah and Purim

Derech Hashem 4:8:2-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 8, second half of paragraph 2, paragraph 3 and the beginning of paragraph 4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 2 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The class is in the seasonal misvot, after the constant misvot and the daily ones. It has covered Shabbat and the festivals, Pesah, and the sukkah: God enveloping us. Unlike Pesah and Shavuot, which are tied to freedom and Torah at their time, the light of Sukkot is available all year, though Sukkot is when it is easiest to reach. Now the class reached the second half of paragraph 2, on the four species.

The four species and God's name

The light of Hakadosh Barukh Hu shines on Israel and crowns them, so that fear of them falls on their enemies, through taking the lulav and the four species. "Remember, it's not the shaking, it's the taking." The verse says, "all the nations of the earth will see that the name of Hashem is called upon you, and they will fear you."

The four species correspond to the four letters of God's name. Really we should see this clearly every time we take them. It is there in potential, as with all misvot, whose effect most of us only see after we die. The details of the misvah, the waving and the circuits, complete it: they strengthen God's rule over us and make our enemies fall before us, until, as the verses in Yeshayahu say, they bow to the ground, and those who afflicted us come bowing before us, humbled and returning to serve God.

A new explanation

"Has anyone ever heard this explanation of the four species before?" The Rabbi called it quite interesting. The standard explanation, closest to the plain meaning, is that all four species need a lot of water. At the start of the winter we take them, recognise that they grow through Hakadosh Barukh Hu, and pray for rain, which is what the Hoshanot and Hoshana Rabbah are about. The Midrashim that compare them to the lips, spine, heart and eyes are lovely, but not the plain meaning.

The Rabbi pointed out what the Ramhal's approach gains. On the standard view, Sukkot has two unrelated misvot: the sukkah commemorates the clouds, and the four species are a prayer for rain. On the Ramhal's view they fit together. The clouds protected us from our enemies and also gave us the Shekhinah. The holiness comes through the sukkah, and the protection through the four species.

A participant said this view made more sense to him, since taking objects to bring down rain sounds close to what idolaters did. The Rabbi answered that for a farmer whose livelihood depends on what grows that year, holding these plants in the synagogue makes the prayer very real. "We don't appreciate it, because we just pay money and get our four species."

Hanukkah: Torah and avodah (paragraph 3)

The Ramhal says Hanukkah brings down the light of what was achieved in those days: the Hashmonaim overpowered the Greeks, who wanted to remove us spiritually rather than kill us, returned Israel to Torah and to the service of the Temple, and relit the menorah.

Under the Greeks Torah could not be learned publicly, and there was no Temple service. The world stands on Torah, avodah and acts of kindness, and Hanukkah restored two of them. So Hanukkah is a spiritual festival: full Hallel with a blessing all eight days, but no misvah of a festive meal. "Hanukkah is not about your body." It is a time especially suited to Torah study, thanksgiving and service, which today means prayer. The menorah stands for the light of Torah, "a misvah is a lamp and Torah is light," against the Greeks who opposed the Torah's whole philosophy.

Purim: body and Torah

Purim is twofold. First, God saved us physically, so we celebrate physically, with food, wine and a good time. Second, as the Gemara says, Israel accepted the Torah again in the days of Ahashverosh, since the first time was under duress. "People don't know this aspect of Purim, unfortunately," and so there is also a reason to learn Torah on Purim. Whatever happened in those days, its light comes again on those days.

The red enemy and the white enemy

The Rabbi recalled an idea he had taught before. We have always had two kinds of enemies: physical ones, like Haman, Amalek and Hitler, who want to kill us; and spiritual ones, like the Greeks or the Spanish Inquisition, whose aim was conversion.

Yaakov had two enemies, Esav and Lavan. Esav is Edom, red; Lavan means white. The Gemara says there are three partners in a person: God gives the soul, the father the white parts such as the brain and nails, and the mother the red parts, blood and flesh. The Rabbi understood this as the mother grounding the child physically and the father teaching intellectually. White is the colour of purity and rationality; red is emotion, danger, love.

Esav wanted to kill Yaakov and draw blood. Lavan spent twenty years tricking him and playing games with his mind. Hanukkah is the white enemy, the intellectual one, so we mark it with Torah and prayer. Purim is the red enemy, the Esav, so we mark it with food and physical celebration.

The shofar (beginning of paragraph 4)

"If you understand this properly, it will really change your Rosh Hashanah." On Rosh Hashanah God judges the world and renews all existence for a new cycle. Just as He created the world thousands of years ago, every Rosh Hashanah is a new creation for the year ahead. A participant asked how this differs from God renewing the world every moment. The Rabbi compared it to making a product: there is the act of creating it, and then constant maintenance to keep it going.

On that day there is a court in session, with prosecution and defence, as in courts here, and the Satan is ready to present the sins of humanity. God commands us to blow the shofar so that the conduct of the coming year will be one of mercy rather than strict justice, and to confuse the prosecutor.

The Rabbi gave the essence in brief, to be explained next time. Everything on Rosh Hashanah is about one thing: that God conducts His judgment with rahamim, not din. We achieve this by living under Him as a son before a father and a subject before a king. Once we are under mercy, everything else falls into place, and there is no need to ask for livelihood or health. Those who focus on their needs "lose the plot". The Zohar compares those who spend Rosh Hashanah crying for their livelihood and health to dogs barking at their master: "You need to be thinking about your relationship with Hakadosh Barukh Hu."

Summary

- For the Ramhal, the four species correspond to God's name and bring fear upon Israel's enemies, completing the protection of the Clouds of Glory, while the sukkah brings the holiness.
- The usual explanation, a prayer for rain, makes the sukkah and the four species two unrelated misvot.
- Hanukkah restored Torah and avodah and is celebrated spiritually; Purim is a physical rescue and a renewed acceptance of the Torah.
- Esav the red enemy wants our blood and Lavan the white enemy our minds: Purim and Hanukkah.
- On Rosh Hashanah the world is recreated and judged; the shofar and our whole aim are to move into God's conduct of mercy.

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